of putting Hakim on the throne. They had failed; Sharafuddin disappeared, for the moment, from the story, and Abul Ma'ali arrived at Kabul's gates.

He sent Mahchuchak a poem.

'We are not come to this door, for the sake of pomp and grandeur / We are come here as a refuge from the evil of circumstances.'

Mahchuchak was not shy of butchering her rivals nor afraid of riding into enemy troops, but she was susceptible, it seems, to self-pitying verse. 'Show kindness and alight, for the house is thy house,' she replied.[61]

Perhaps, having shut her gates in Akbar's face, and knowing that Sulaiman of Badakhshan and his wife Haram Begum still looked upon her realm as their prey, Mahchuchak felt the need for an ally. Not only did she invite Abul Ma'ali into her citadel, she married him to her daughter. But Mahchuchak had misjudged her new son-in-law. Kindness was not his strong suit; and her house would soon be his, alone.

Abul Ma'ali was 'obviously vile',[62] writes Abul Fazl – and no one can accuse the historian, here, of exaggeration. What followed was horrific.

Hakim was eight years old at this time but, as Babur's grandson, he commanded a certain customary allegiance from the people of Kabul, and was an asset, therefore, to anyone who sought to rule the city. His mother was not.

The scene is gruesome. Abul Ma'ali stormed into Mahchuchak's house, with two other men. There was a group of women, one of whom looked a bit like the queen; they killed her first and realized their error later. The three men resumed their search for the begum, striding through the house, weapons drawn. She had locked herself in a room; they broke down the door – you can imagine the sound of their hammering and the screams of the women behind them. There is no account of whether Mahchuchak cowered when they barged in, or put up a fight. Perhaps the begum had time to let fly a round of curses on their heads. But then, they stabbed her.

Leaving Mahchuchak's butchered body behind, the three men went to look for the children and plucked Hakim from amongst them. The eight-year-old orphan went straight from the nursery to the throne.

Abul Ma'ali would not enjoy his ill-gotten gains for long. The child-king's supporters had him write to his uncle, Sulaiman of Badakhshan; and, 'accompanied by Haram',[63] no doubt with some glee, he rode to the rescue.